

Lie to me

If you look at all the problems the world faces today, all of them are man-made. People are racist, biased, narcissistic, illogical, greedy and devious, and cause all the pain and suffering in the world. However, there are also social workers, researchers and various groups and organisations that work tirelessly for the greater good. The duality of man, so to speak.

Technology, though, doesn't yet display this duality. Take the net, for example; you'll find anything from terrorist groups to hacker hangouts, and yet you also find Wikipedia and thinkdigit.com – all of it in a matter of seconds, thanks to search engines. This is because current technology doesn't seem to care less about your character, or try and chaperone your actions.

Most of us would immediately be up in arms at the suggestion of smart, moral machines trying to tell us what to do. However, isn't it better for technology to prevent you from doing something that could harm yourself or others?

A popular example of this comes from sci-fi – Asimov's Robots had Positronic brains that were programmed with the Three Laws of Robotics, and had to prevent people from hurting themselves.

We'd be fine with machines that stop a deranged man from committing suicide, or stop a drunk from getting behind the wheel of a car. Perhaps we'd even be OK with machines stopping us from learning how to build a bomb.

Not too many of us would want a machine that would stop us from eating burgers, and perhaps not a single one of us would allow a mere machine to dictate what we should or shouldn't read. Never! Right?

Wrong. They've already been doing it for years!

When you conduct a simple image search on Google, for instance; by default, Google attempts to hide pornography from you – unsuccessfully at times. Of course, all it needs is a simple override from you (Turn Safe Search off) to be able to display all results without censorship.

Perhaps we will build manual overrides into an all smart technology in the future. However, a Google-style override would mean that you could order your car's AI system to shut down before you decide to start driving after a few drinks; thus rendering the technology totally pointless.

Our insecurities will stand in the way of such advancements, though. However, just as we cannot imagine life in the uncivilised days of the barbarians, future generations will look back at us with equal disgust. Humanity will get used

to machines being better and smarter than us for some tasks eventually, because each generation will have lived with more advanced technology than the previous one.

None of us today question an anti-virus when it claims a certain file is infected. That's because the antivirus is *smarter* than us when it comes to identifying malicious code. I'm allowing my word processor to spell-check this column as I type it, because I *trust* that it's right when it tells me I haven't made any spelling mistakes yet.

Sticking to the drunk driver example, what we'd need is technology that's smart enough to *pretend* to shut down, and stay that way unless the driver tried to do something idiotic. Maybe a more advanced version would *empathise* with a human's need to appear to be in control, and compensate for drunkenness by aiding the driver to steer his car undetected. Deceitful, yes, but a lot better than the simplistic black and white, right and wrong solutions that binary machines throw at us today.

We need an AI that's not just smart, but also displays human traits. Only if it exhibits some of the duality of man, will it blend in seamlessly with us, and be allowed to save us from ourselves. 



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PS: If you want a glimpse into the future, on page 66-67, you'll find a rather complicated-looking road map. Look at the legend on the right and choose a path you want to follow. The colour coding on the left will tell you which year span you're currently viewing.

Some examples of what you'll find:

- *The last ever CD will be published in 2018.*
- *Pets will out-number people by around 2015.*
- *Robots will outnumber humans by 2035.*
- *Brain scans for job interviews by 2025.*
- *Humility will be in partial ruin by 2050.*
- *We'll have a global e-currency by 2040.*

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